

Part I — The Rehearsal

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The curtain rises on a bare stage with a circle of chairs and nothing else. Working lights. No furniture, no flats, no props. The Manager arrives at his theatre to a half-rehearsed company seated in those chairs in various postures of professional boredom. The play they are meant to rehearse this morning is one of Pirandello's own — *Mixing It Up* — which the Manager believes is unstageable, and which his contract has forced him to stage anyway. He bickers with the Leading Man about being asked to wear a cook's cap in a serious play. He insults the playwright. He insults the script. He insults the conditions under which any working theatre is forced to operate. None of this surprises his actors, who have heard it before; some are tying their shoes, some are reading the paper, none is rehearsing.

The Prompter takes his place in the box, complaining about the draught. The Property Man enters with furniture for an entirely different scene than the one being rehearsed. The Door-keeper waits at the back of the house with a stack of unread letters. The apparatus of the working theatre — irritation, vanity, exhaustion, the small professional dignities — is performing itself, for nobody it knows is watching.

The audience watches all of this comedy and does not yet know it is watching a comedy. The play has not announced itself. We are inside the engine room of the production, not the production. There is no Pirandello here yet, except in the contract burning quietly on the table.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

The spectators will find the curtain raised and the stage as it usually is during the day time. It will be half dark, and empty, so that from the beginning the public may have the impression of an impromptu performance. Prompter's box and a small table and chair for the manager.

Two other small tables and several chairs scattered about as during rehearsals.

*The **Actors** and **Actresses** of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. They are about to rehearse a Pirandello play: *Mixing it Up*. [Il giuoco delle parti.] Some of the company move off towards their dressing rooms. The **Prompter** who has the "book" under his arm, is waiting for the manager in order to begin the rehearsal.*

*The **Players**, some standing, some sitting, chat in two languages and check their phones. One scrolls yesterday's 24 heures; another mutters her lines under her breath. Somebody, in the wings, is making coffee.*

*Finally, the **Manager** enters with the precise weariness of a man who has been managing the Village Players for too long. He goes to the table prepared for him. His **Secretary** brings him his mail, through which he glances with the expression of one who has never, in his life, received good news from an envelope. The **Prompter** takes his seat, turns on a light, and opens the "book."*

Authority dressed as irritation: he throws letters, demands light, and claims the room before a single actor has spoken.

THE MANAGER [throwing the morning's letter onto the table]. I can't see a thing in here. [To **Property Man**.] A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

Her body has been at work for an hour while management arrives fresh; the forward lean earns no acknowledgment.

PLAYER 2 *[she has been at work for an hour; the Property Man's bearing — shoulders forward, weight on the front foot].* Yes, sir. At once. *[A light comes down on to the stage.]*

Clapping hands are a conductor's baton here, but the barb — 'if you wanted the public to come back' — betrays how little he trusts his own company.

THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands].* Come along! Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and try, this time, to play it as if you wanted the public to come back for the third. *[Sits down.] [The Actors and Actresses go from the front of the stage to the wings, all except the three who are to begin the rehearsal.]*

Vanity wrapped in nostalgia: the anecdote is aimed at no one and meant for everyone, a man reminding the room he once mattered.

PLAYER 1 *[settling himself, to no one].* The public came back for the third act once. I was in it.

A fictional domestic space is read aloud into being — mundane enough to make the real family's agony, when it arrives, all the more violent.

PLAYER 3 *[reading the "book"].* "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

Reducing all aesthetic choice to a single adjective, he proves the material doesn't interest him, only the schedule.

THE MANAGER *[to Property Man].* Fix up the old red room.

She converts his laziness into logistics without a flicker of complaint; 'I'll turn them round' is institutional compromise rendered as comedy.

PLAYER 2 *[noting it down, not looking up].* Red set. *[A beat.]* Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

Eggs being beaten, roles nested inside roles — the Prompter reads domesticity into existence just before a family arrives whose domesticity is genuine catastrophe.

PLAYER 3 *[reading from the "book"].* "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, dressed in cook's cap and apron is busy beating an egg in a cup. Philip, also dressed as a cook, is beating another egg. Guido Venanzi is seated and listening."

Pre-emptive capitulation: he knows the budget answer before he asks, and 'Mime them' folds art and economy into a single weary command.

THE MANAGER *[wearily, before anyone can object].* Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. *[It does not.]* Mime them.

What troubles him is not the cap but the image — fifteen years of persona-building threatened by a prop.

PLAYER 1 *[to Manager].* Excuse me, but must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

Hiding behind the text, he defers to 'it says so there' rather than defend any choice as his own.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed].* I imagine so. It says so there anyway. *[Pointing to the "book."]*

Tenure weaponised as vanity: the fifteen-year credential is not an argument for the play but a shield for the ego.

PLAYER 1 *[a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line].* But it's ridiculous. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, sir, and not one inch built on a cook's cap.

Flat, unhurried irony does what a speech could not — the cap that finally finishes him, delivered without mercy or emphasis.

PLAYER 2 *[not looking up from her clipboard].* Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

An explosion that is itself a performance: frustration at the whole theatrical enterprise disguised as an absurd lecture on symbolic eggs, control lost and recovered with practiced ease.

THE MANAGER [*jumping up in a rage*]. Ridiculous? Ridiculous? Is it my fault if France won't send us any more good comedies — Paris seems to be keeping them all for itself — and we are reduced to putting on Pirandello, whom nobody understands, including (I am beginning to suspect) Pirandello himself, who plays the fool with all of us and pockets the royalties from the comfort of the grave? [*The Actors grin. The Manager goes to Leading Man and shouts.*] Yes sir, you put on the cook's cap and beat eggs. Do you suppose that with all this egg-beating business you are on an ordinary stage? Get that out of your head. You represent the shell of the eggs you are beating! [*Laughter and comments among the Actors.*] Silence! and listen to my explanations, please! [*To Leading Man.*] "The empty form of reason without the fullness of instinct, which is blind." — You stand for reason, your wife is instinct. It's a mixing up of the parts, according to which you who act your own part become the puppet of yourself. Do you understand?

The resignation threat deflates the instant it leaves his mouth; the beat of silence that follows confirms the hierarchy neither man needed to say aloud.

PLAYER 1 [*the threat empty; both of them know it*]. I'd sooner resign. [*A beat. Nobody moves to stop him.*] I won't. But I'd sooner.

Calling it a 'glorious failure' in advance is a defence, not candour — catastrophe rebranded so he cannot be held responsible for it.

THE MANAGER. Wouldn't we all, sir. But let's get on with it. It's sure to be a glorious failure anyway — and a glorious failure is the closest thing this house has to a guarantee. [*Confidentially.*] But I say, please face three-quarters. Otherwise — what with the abstruseness of the dialogue, the public that won't be able to hear a word of it, and the critics who will hear far too much — the whole thing will go to hell. And I'll be blamed for all of it. Come on. Come on.

Dignity salvaged through protest: wearing the cap 'under protest' is the last move available to a man who has already lost the argument.

PLAYER 1 [*settling the cook's cap on his head with the dignity of a man mounting the scaffold*]. Let the record show that I wear it under protest.

A draughty door and a first proper season ground the scene in the fragile, specific aspirations of a working actor.

PLAYER 3. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they still haven't mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

Brisk assent that barely registers the human behind the request; comfort here is administrative, not personal.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, of course!

The white working lights soften into a warm amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The Door-keeper enters from the stage door carrying the Boy-chair — the black coat over its back, the cap on its seat, the satchel by its leg — sets it at the edge of the stage, and advances towards the Manager's table, taking off his braided cap. During this manoeuvre, the four live Characters — Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son — enter, and stop by the door at back of stage. The Step-Daughter is already carrying the Child-bundle.

A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them — the faint breath of their fantastic reality.

This tenuous light will disappear when they come forward towards the actors. They preserve, however, something of the dream lightness in which they seem almost suspended; but this does not detract from the essential reality of their forms and expressions.

He who is known as **The Father** is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.

The Mother seems crushed and terrified as if by an intolerable weight of shame and abasement. She is dressed in modest black and wears a thick widow's veil of crêpe. When she lifts this, she reveals a wax-like face. She always keeps her eyes downcast.

The Step-Daughter is dashing, almost impudent, beautiful. She wears mourning too, but with great elegance. She shows contempt for the wretched Boy-chair at the edge of the stage; she shows a lively tenderness for the Child-bundle in her arms.

The Son (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for **The Father**, supercilious and indifferent to **The Mother**. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.